

Spark is a solo role-playing game that hopes to teach compassion and give tools to healthily cope with burnout, apathy, and anxiety. This is demonstrated by simulating burnout-based struggles for a character named Carmen, where the player helps her choose between resting, interacting, or persisting through each challenge. Every choice affects Carmen's Spark, the small flame that makes life feel worth living, and reminds both Carmen and the player that small acts of compassion can change everything.

	Carmen is a stellar high school student who is experiencing academic burnout. She pushes herself to achieve great things but without healthy rest, she will fall and lose herself. She needs help, your help.		Sal is a fluffy cloud creature who guides Carmen through burnout based struggles by helping her make healthy, appropriate choices. You can be Sal, if you accept this role.
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GAME MECHANICS

To play Spark, you need 1 D6 and 1 deck of cards. No need for Jokers.

There are 2 meters to keep track of throughout the game: Spark and Energy.

Spark represents the will to take initiative and live a thriving life.

Energy represents the energy to take action in life.

INITIAL SPARK/ENERGY VALUES

Roll the die once for Spark. Roll again for Energy. These are Carmen's numbers at the start of the day.

UNIVERSAL ROLL OUTCOMES

1-2: Fail – Energy 0, Spark -1

3-4: Success with consequences – Energy +1, Spark +1

5-6: Clean Success – Energy +2, Spark +2

WILDCARDS

Q - Redraw 3 new cards or keep current hand.

K - Chance to roll twice.

CARD VALUE REFERENCES

- Clubs – Morning – Home
- Diamond – Midday – Classroom
- Heart – Afternoon – Library/Park
- Spades – Night – Home

HOW TO WIN?

If Carmen's final Spark is higher than where she started, you win. But if it isn't, that is okay too. Some days are hard. The game ends when the night suit is complete or when Spark reaches zero. Rest is not failure.

HOW TO PLAY:

- Roll the die to set your starting Spark and Energy levels.
- Separate the deck by suit. Each suit represents a time of day.
- Separate each suit into 2 sections: A – 5 and 6 – K. Shuffle both separately.
- Begin with Clubs. Draw 1 card from Ace to 5. This is Carmen's struggle.
- Draw 3 more cards from the same suit. These are Sal's possible choices.
- Read all three choice cards. Pick the one that fits Carmen's struggle best.
- Roll the die. Apply the universal outcome to Carmen's Spark and Energy.
- If Queen appears in your hand, you may discard all 3 and draw 3 new choice cards, or keep what you have.
- If King appears, you may roll the die twice and take the better result.
- Repeat steps 3 through 8 for Diamonds, Hearts, and Spades.
- At the end of the day, compare your final Spark to your starting Spark. If it is higher, Carmen's day had light in it. You helped her find it.

CARDS: A – 5 ARE CHALLENGES TO FACE | 6 – J ARE CHOICES TO MAKE | Q & K ARE WILDCARDS.

If the energy reaches zero, spark decreases by 1 at the end of each suit.

If spark reaches zero, the game ends early; Carmen needs rest. That is okay too. Rest is not failure.

SPARK TRACKER

Initial:	Morning:	Midday:	Afternoon:	Night:	Final:
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ENERGY TRACKER

Initial:	Morning:	Midday:	Afternoon:	Night:	Final:
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CARD SUIT

You may notice similar choices appearing throughout the day. This is intentional. Burnout asks the same questions repeatedly. How you answer them each time is what matters.

Card Value	Clubs (Morning - Home)	Diamonds (Midday- Classroom)	Heart (Afternoon- Library/Park)	Spades (Night - Home)
A	Carmen's eyes open before her alarm. Her mind is already listing. Her hand finds her phone to scroll.	Carmen is outside the classroom. Class begins in five minutes. Her hands are shaking.	Carmen has found a quiet corner. Her phone buzzes. A friend: "hey, coffee? it's been forever."	The living room is warm and loud. Her family is mid-game and laughing. They wave her over.
2	Test today. Carmen's body is heavy. She doesn't feel ready.	The test has begun. She's on question seven. Her thoughts are racing faster than her pen.	Carmen came to the park. Her friend pulls her toward the tag game. Her notebook sits on the bench.	Carmen is considering setting up tomorrow's to-do list. But maybe tomorrow can wait until tomorrow.
3	Dishes from last night. Floor needs sweeping. Carmen sees the kitchen and feels the weight.	The Teacher is reviewing last minute notes. Carmen's mind is somewhere else entirely.	A soft library corner. Eyes heavy. A novel she loves sits in her bag.	Carmen is getting ready for bed. She knows she should stretch. Her body says otherwise tonight.
4	Carmen's chest is tight. The to-do list is long. Her thoughts are moving too fast.	Test is over. Friends are comparing answers. Every right answer they got feels personal.	A friend stops. "Are you okay? You look really tired." They mean it.	The house is quiet. Carmen is replaying the day, the test, the things left unsaid and said.
5	Carmen is not hungry. She knows she should eat. But food feels like one more thing to do.	The test is over. Her crush is right there. Same class, same test, same hallway. She could go talk to him.	Carmen opens her to-do list. Things from this morning sit undone. The guilt of an incomplete day settles in.	Her mom knocks softly. "How did today go, mija?" She is looking at Carmen the way only a mother looks.
6	Put the phone face down. One small thing at a time.	Whisper something true. You studied. You are ready. One question at a time.	Rest. Carmen's body is tired and it is asking clearly. Honor that without guilt.	Join them. You don't have to be fully present. Just be in the same room. That is enough.
7	Let Carmen rest a little longer. Her body is asking clearly. Ten more minutes, then begin.	Let the moment pass. Carmen is already drained. Protecting her energy is a valid choice.	Choose something low energy and joyful. Sometimes rest looks like a quiet hobby, not sleep.	Let Carmen rest without conditions. The day is done. Her body has earned this.
8	Nudge Carmen toward gentle stretches. Her body will carry her again today.	Let Carmen stay with her friends. Connection might loosen what the test tightened.	Say yes to the invitation. Engagement creates connection and connection creates light.	Push through the stretches gently. Keeping one small habit alive is an act of self respect.
9	Sit with Carmen in the overwhelm. Name it. Pick just one thing.	Gently bring Carmen back to the board. This review might hold exactly what she needs.	Speak one true thing. Not everything. Just enough to let someone in a little.	Speak one true thing to her mom. Not everything. Just enough to feel a little less alone.
10	Encourage Carmen to eat something small. Enough to tell her body it matters.	Encourage Carmen to step away. The test is done. What comes next matters more than score.	Stay surface level. Carmen doesn't have to let everyone in. Holding it together is enough.	Set up tomorrow's list tonight. Giving tomorrow a shape makes it feel less like a wall.
J	Remind Carmen of one true thing: she woke up. That is already something.	Nudge Carmen toward him. Something small. Even just hi. That is enough to begin.	Remind Carmen that showing up today, even imperfectly, was already something.	Let tomorrow come as it comes. Carmen has enough to carry tonight. The rest can wait.
Q	Chance to redraw 3 cards and refresh your hand.			
K	Chance to reroll twice. Highest value of the two rolls will be taken into account.			